

THE CREDIT LINE

Banks and AI: A Credit-Positive Outlook



Banks and AI: Fee Opportunities and Efficiency Gains

Following our [June](#) review of how investment-grade non-financial firms discuss AI, we assess US and European bank commentary in earnings calls and other disclosures. Our key conclusion is that AI is likely to be credit-positive for banks through two channels. First, they can monetize the AI capex cycle through advisory, underwriting, syndication, asset-management and selective lending revenues. Second, they can deploy AI internally to support automation and cost discipline. The AI capex theme is most pronounced among US banks, but the efficiency angle is evident in both regions.

Facilitating the Capex Cycle

US banks are far more likely than non-financial firms to discuss AI capex on earnings calls, reflecting the commercial opportunities created by the buildout. Banks can arrange construction facilities, bridge financing and project packages while distributing longer-dated risk to institutional and private-market investors. The potential opportunity set includes a wide range of capital markets and financing activity (debt and equity), trading intermediation, and hedging. The Fed's January 2026 Senior Loan Officer Opinion Survey points to banks' greater willingness to lend to firms expected to benefit from AI, and we expect them to take a more active lending role if capacity in traditional syndicated markets becomes constrained. Given the scale of the anticipated AI-related capex need, we also continue to expect the private markets will play an increasingly important role in the financing. Our [equity colleagues](#) recently highlighted a growing supply-demand imbalance for AI and expect the capex cycle to remain elevated through the end of 2027.

Reaffirming Our Overweight Stance on Banks

AI-related activity has contributed at the margin to higher USD bank supply, in contrast to relatively flat EUR IG bank supply. Elevated USD bank issuance reflects both opportunistic funding amid tight spreads and greater balance-sheet use for prime-brokerage financing and C&I lending across the AI ecosystem. While this is a technical headwind for USD banks, we think it is outweighed by the associated fee, financing, and efficiency benefits, which should support credit fundamentals. Banks' overall share of USD IG gross supply has also remained broadly stable at roughly 40%, while technology's share has increased sharply towards 20%.

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In June, we reviewed earnings transcripts and regulatory filings across investment-grade non-financial corporations in the USD and EUR credit markets. Our key takeaway was that, while management teams increasingly frame AI as a productivity opportunity, evidence that these benefits are materializing at scale remains limited.

We also argued that the AI buildout is becoming a major driver of corporate funding needs. AI-related issuers have already contributed meaningfully to debt supply this year, and we expect the funding burden to broaden as more firms finance their own AI capex. Reflecting this dynamic, we recently raised our 2026 USD IG gross supply forecast to \$2.3 trillion from \$2.1 trillion and penciled in \$2.4 trillion for 2027, setting the stage for two consecutive years of record gross issuance.

This week, we turn to banks. Our review of earnings calls, regulatory filings and transcript data across the largest investment-grade US and European banks suggests that AI is credit-positive for the sector through two channels, which directly inform fundamental metrics:

- **Fee generation and ecosystem lending:** Banks can capture advisory, debt and equity underwriting, and syndication revenues from the AI capex cycle while generally limiting retained long-dated infrastructure risk. At the same time, banks may expand lending and financing across the broader AI ecosystem, including hyperscaler suppliers, equipment providers and clients trading AI-related securities. While banks may deploy balance sheet lending capacity through bridge facilities, construction lending, and underwriting commitments, we expect them to remain selective in retaining large, long-dated exposures.
- **Internal operating efficiency:** Banks are deploying AI to support process automation, cost discipline and efficiency gains.

Both themes are particularly evident among US banks. Reflecting this, while EUR IG bank supply remains broadly flat year to date, USD IG bank issuance is running at a record pace. We think this reflects opportunistic pre-funding of upcoming maturities amid tight spreads, as well as, at the margin, greater balance-sheet needs related to AI-linked trading and lending activity. While this elevated supply represents a technical headwind for USD banks, we think it is outweighed by the associated fee, financing, and efficiency benefits. This reinforces our preference for banks vs. non-financials.

More broadly, recent headlines have focused some market participants on the potential pace of the AI buildout. Our equity colleagues recently highlighted a growing supply-demand imbalance for AI and expect the capex cycle to remain elevated through the end of 2027.

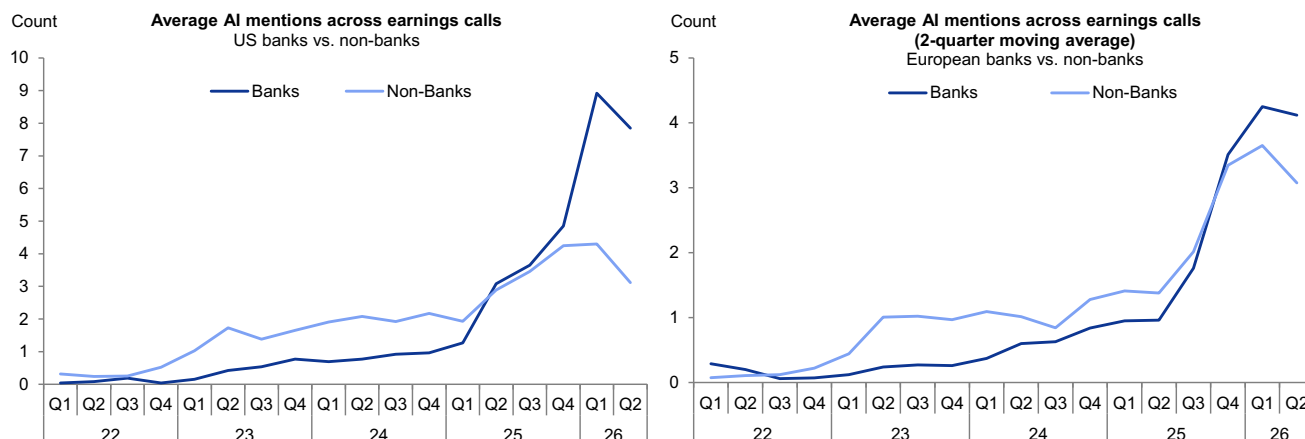
This multi-trillion-dollar scale of the AI infrastructure buildout remains too large for bank balance sheets and public syndicated markets to fund alone, in our view. We therefore expect private credit, specialized infrastructure platforms, real estate funds and institutional asset managers to provide an increasingly important share of long-duration capital. Large banks should nevertheless remain pivotal as originators, structuring agents, underwriters and liquidity providers across the AI financing ecosystem.

1. Banks Outpace Non-Financial Issuers in AI Mentions

AI has become an increasingly important theme in bank earnings calls. On average, AI was mentioned roughly nine times per US bank call and four times per European bank call in Q2 2026 (Exhibit 1). Banks have consistently discussed AI more frequently than non-financial firms since 2025H2, coinciding with the broader adoption of more advanced AI models.

Exhibit 1: The AI narrative is increasingly a bank narrative

Average AI mentions per earnings call; Banks vs. Non-Banks

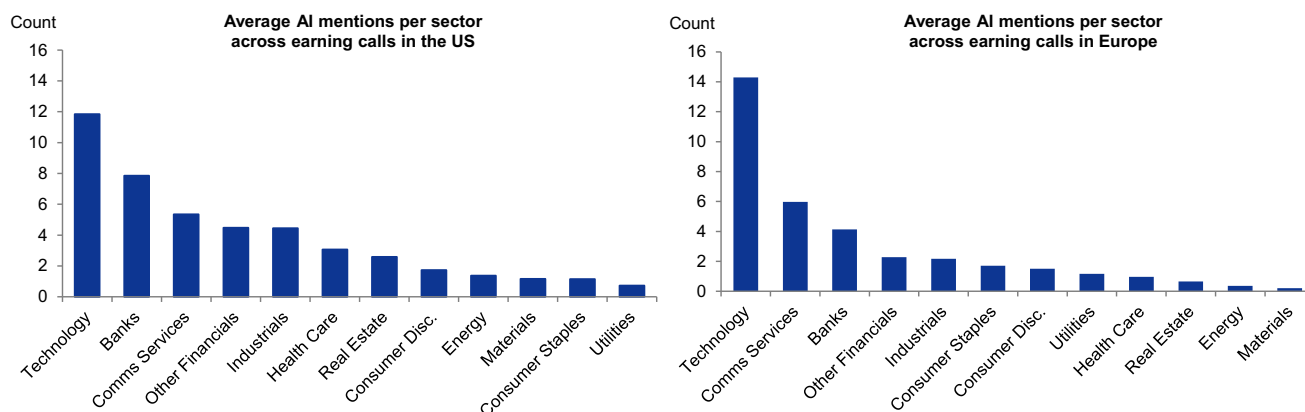


Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, LSEG Data & Analytics

On a sector basis, US banks ranked behind only technology, excluding hyperscalers, in terms of AI mentions in Q2. European banks ranked behind technology and communication services (Exhibit 2). However, there remains meaningful dispersion across firms. In the US, nearly every bank in our sample mentioned AI at least once, with the largest banks mentioning AI the most (Exhibit 3). Conversely, in Europe, several smaller European banks did not raise the topic at all.

Exhibit 2: US banks screen second only to technology on AI mentions

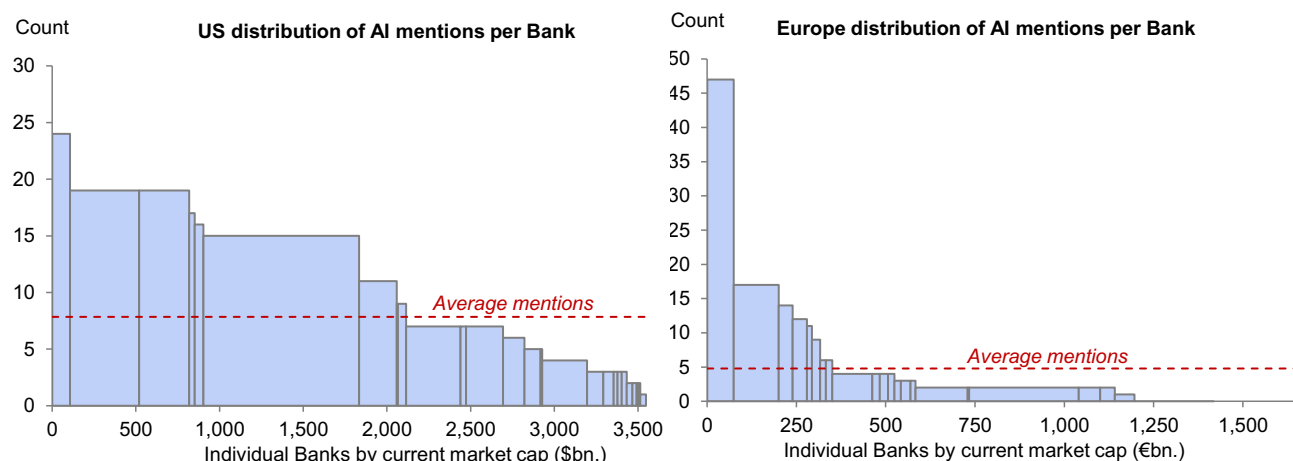
Average AI mentions by sector, Q2 2026



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, LSEG Data & Analytics

Exhibit 3: The AI conversation is concentrated in the largest banks in the US

Distribution of AI mentions across banks



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, LSEG Data & Analytics

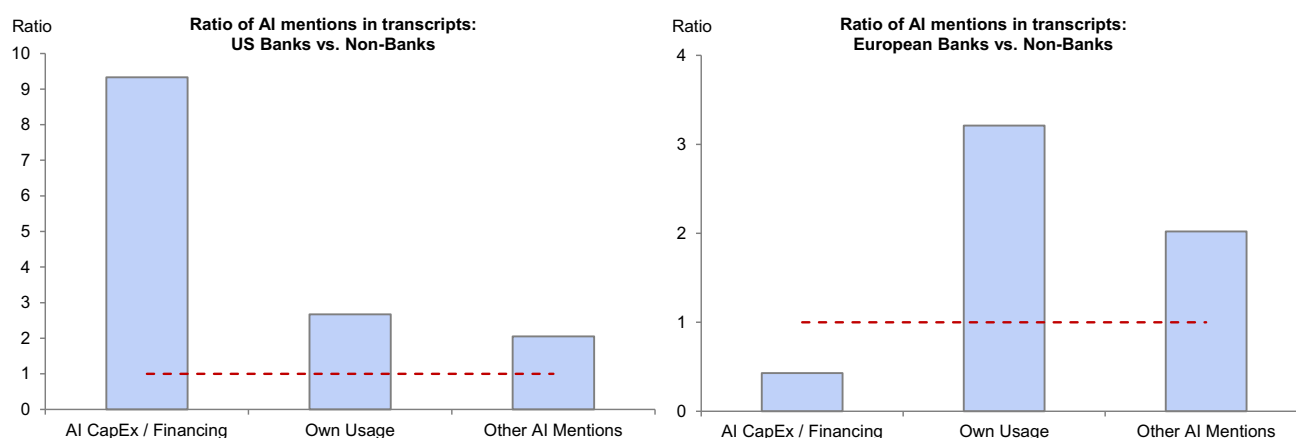
2. AI Capex: Capital-Light Participation, With Scope for Broader Lending

Looking closely at transcript themes, US banks are roughly nine times more likely than non-financial corporations to reference AI capex on earnings calls (Exhibit 4). By contrast, European banks discuss AI capex less frequently, reflecting the fact that the physical infrastructure buildout, particularly hyperscale computing and data center capacity, remains concentrated in the US.

The increased focus of US banks on AI is also consistent with the Federal Reserve's Senior Loan Officer Opinion Survey, where banks reported a greater willingness to lend to firms expected to benefit from AI exposure and less willingness to lend to firms adversely affected by AI. This suggests that AI considerations are increasingly entering underwriting frameworks (Exhibit 5).

Exhibit 4: US banks discuss AI capex more frequently than non-financial firms

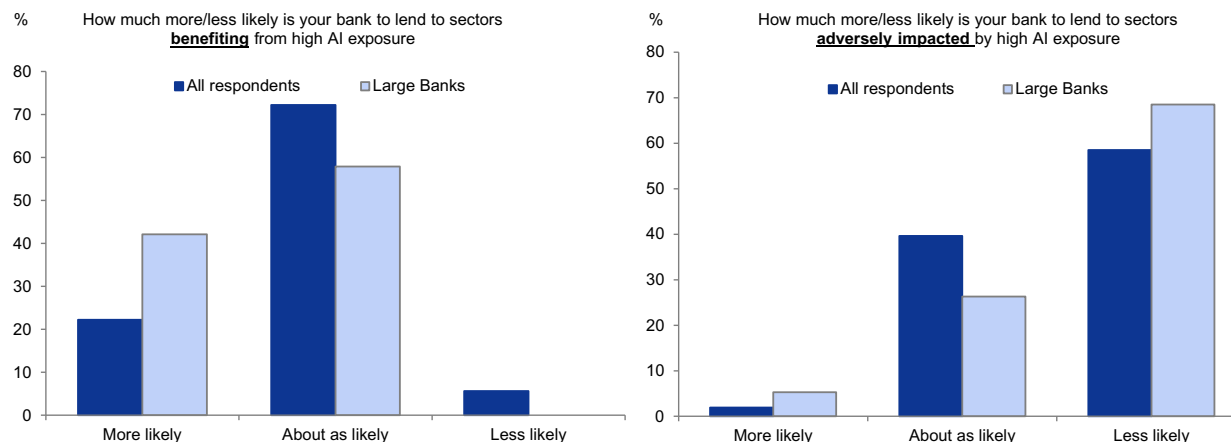
AI capex mentions by banks vs. non-banks



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, LSEG Data & Analytics

Exhibit 5: AI exposure is entering underwriting frameworks

Net willingness to lend by perceived AI exposure vs. January 2025



Source: The Federal Reserve's January 2026 Senior Loan Officer Opinion Survey, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Our review of the eight largest US and ten largest public European banks suggests that direct retained balance-sheet exposure to AI infrastructure remains limited so far. These banks account for roughly 50% of US bank debt outstanding in the Bloomberg USD credit index, and 40% of European banks in the EUR IG corporate credit index. So far and based on our review, only one US bank disclosed direct lending to data-center projects, while another highlighted a strategic partnership related to the AI buildout (Exhibit 6). Most other banks discussed AI capex in broad commercial terms. European banks were somewhat more forthcoming on specific facilities, but overall disclosures suggest that direct exposure remains modest (at least for now).

The Chicago Fed supervisory data support this conclusion: direct outstanding exposure to AI-adjacent sectors among large US banks represents just 0.8% of total bank assets, or roughly 9% of Tier 1 capital, rising to 25% when undrawn commitments are included. However, this likely understates banks' broader AI-related balance-sheet exposure. Beyond direct lending to data centers and hyperscalers, banks may provide C&I lending to suppliers expanding capacity for the AI infrastructure buildout, as well as prime-brokerage and other financing to clients trading AI-related equities. Such activity is less likely to be disclosed explicitly as AI-related lending, but could become a more meaningful source of balance-sheet usage as the capex cycle broadens.

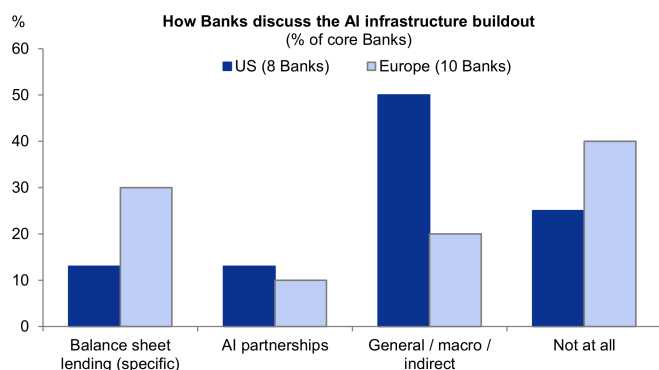
For now, disclosures point to a predominantly capital-light, originate-to-distribute model. Banks can structure construction facilities, bridge financing and project packages for data centers, semiconductor manufacturing and power generation before distributing a meaningful share of longer-dated credit risk to institutional investors. The opportunity is nevertheless meaningful, particularly in the US. Several of the largest US banks have announced financing initiatives linked to data centers, semiconductor capacity and related infrastructure (Exhibit 7). Our US Banks equity research analysts estimate that AI-related activity has accounted for roughly 50%-55% of year-to-date growth in investment-banking volumes and fees, as well as around 40% of 1H2026 Equities revenue growth.

As financing volumes rise and traditional syndicated capacity is increasingly utilized, banks may deploy balance sheet lending capacity through bridge facilities, underwriting commitments, trading inventory, hedging and other capital-markets activities. This

should particularly benefit large US banks with broad capital markets, financing, and trading platforms. However, in the near term we expect banks to remain selective in retaining large, long-dated AI infrastructure exposures, with a meaningful share of ultimate risk likely to be distributed to institutional and private-market investors.

Exhibit 6: Direct AI lending disclosure remains minimal across major banks

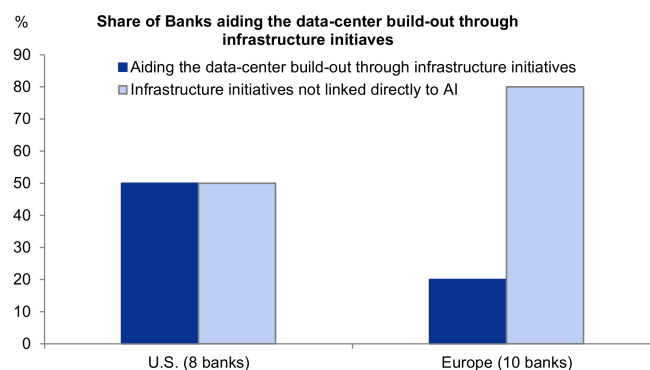
Direct balance-sheet AI lending disclosures across the 8 largest US and 10 largest European banks



Source: Company Transcripts, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 7: AI infrastructure represents a capital-light fee opportunity

AI infrastructure financing initiatives across the 8 largest US and 10 largest European banks



Source: Company Announcements, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

3. Productivity and Operating Efficiency Take Center Stage

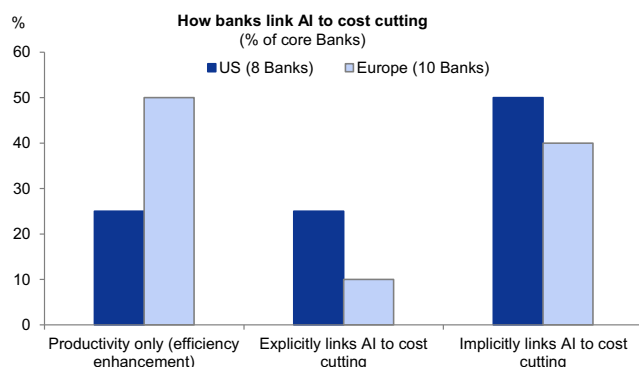
When discussing internal AI deployment, we found that banks focus primarily on efficiency gains through automation, as well as cost control. Every bank in our sample cited operating efficiency or process automation as a key objective. Management teams often bundle AI initiatives with broader digital transformation and IT modernization programs, with this theme more pronounced in the US than in Europe (Exhibit 8).

This is consistent with the conclusions of our [European bank analysts](#), who expect the main benefit of AI for banks to come through cost containment and efficiency-ratio improvement. This differs from non-financial firms, where our [earlier review](#) found that fewer than 10% linked AI directly to cost cutting.

Banks provide limited disclosures on AI expenditures. Only one European bank disclosed AI-specific expenses, while roughly one-quarter of banks include AI spending within broader technology budgets. The remainder do not disclose dedicated AI budgets at all (Exhibit 9).

Exhibit 8: US banks are further along in linking AI to cost cutting

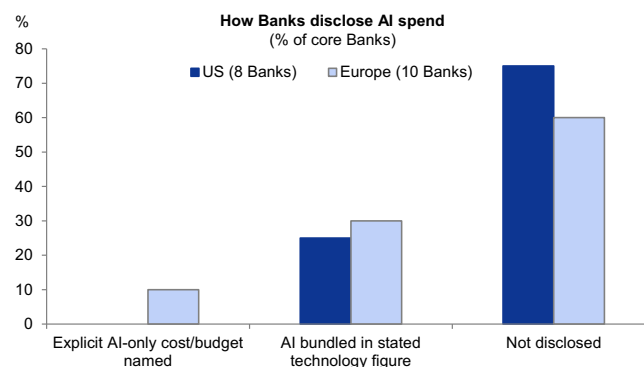
Share of banks citing AI or technology-enabled efficiency initiatives



Source: Company Transcripts, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 9: Most banks do not disclose their AI expenditures

AI-specific spend disclosure among large banks



There are zero observations for US banks in the first category.

Source: Company Transcripts, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

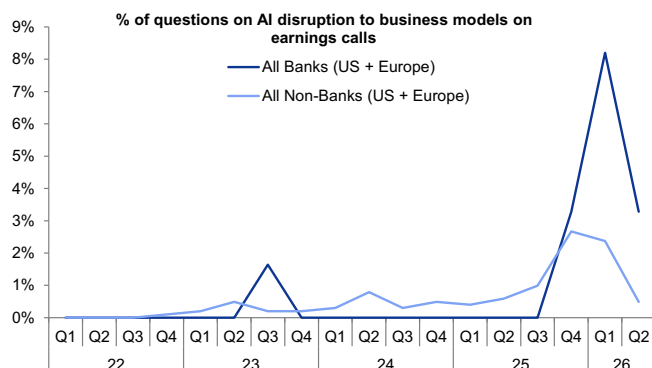
4. AI Disruption Concerns Have Shifted Towards Cyber Risk

Finally, earlier this year, banks faced increased scrutiny over concerns about AI-driven disruption to bank business models, including faster deposit repricing or lower customer switching costs. However, these now appear to have subsided in earnings-call discussions (Exhibit 10). Within risk disclosures, only one major bank identified structural business-model disruption as a material AI risk. Even then, the concern was primarily the risk of falling behind peers in AI adoption.

Instead, cyber and operational resilience have become the more prominent focus areas vis-à-vis potential AI-related risks (Exhibit 11). Banks are increasingly focused on the potential for AI-enabled cyberattacks, fraud, software vulnerabilities and operational failures. This also appears consistent with the growing supervisory focus on AI-related operational and cyber risk. For instance, the ECB has directed significant institutions to submit formal remediation plans addressing AI-enabled cyber risks, information and communication technology (ICT) governance, and operational security weaknesses.

Exhibit 10: AI as a business model disruption risk has faded from earnings-call narratives

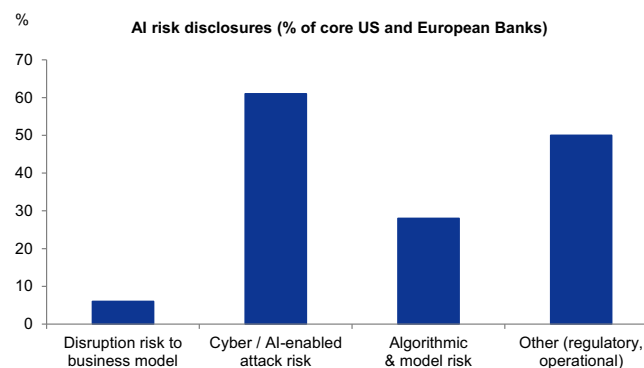
Share of AI-related questions focused on business model disruption



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, LSEG Data & Analytics

Exhibit 11: Banks flag cyber risk, not business model disruption

AI-related risk disclosures among large banks



Source: Company Transcripts, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

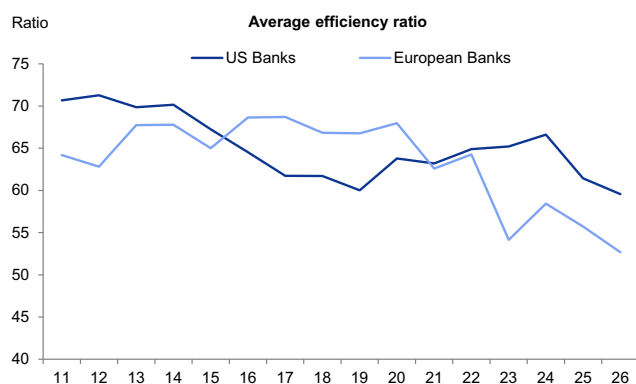
Credit Implications: Reaffirming Our Overweight Stance on Banks

AI adoption reinforces our constructive view on the banking sector. While the opportunity is more pronounced in the US, we think banks in both the US and Europe stand to benefit relative to non-financial firms in their respective markets. Banks can capture advisory, underwriting, syndication and asset-management fees from the AI capex cycle while generally limiting retained long-dated infrastructure credit and duration risk. AI-related efficiency gains and cost discipline should also support further improvement in efficiency ratios (Exhibit 12).

We therefore reiterate our overweight recommendation on banks vs. non-financial sectors, particularly technology. USD bank spreads have outperformed technology year to date, and we expect this relative performance to continue (Exhibit 13). The key consideration is the divergent trajectory for leverage and supply: technology companies are utilizing their significant balance sheet flexibility to fund AI capex, contributing to a material increase in debt issuance. Technology now accounts for roughly 20% of USD IG gross supply this year, up from around 5% in 2024 (Exhibit 14).

Exhibit 12: Falling efficiency ratios underscore the cost discipline focus in the banks sector

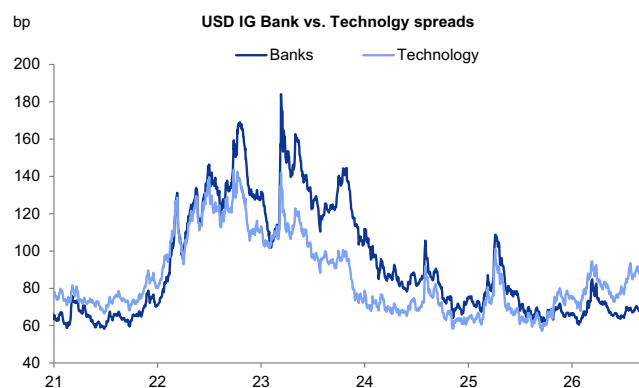
Bank efficiency ratios across US and European large-cap banks



Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 13: USD Banks have outperformed Technology spreads this year

Spread performance: Banks vs. Technology



Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

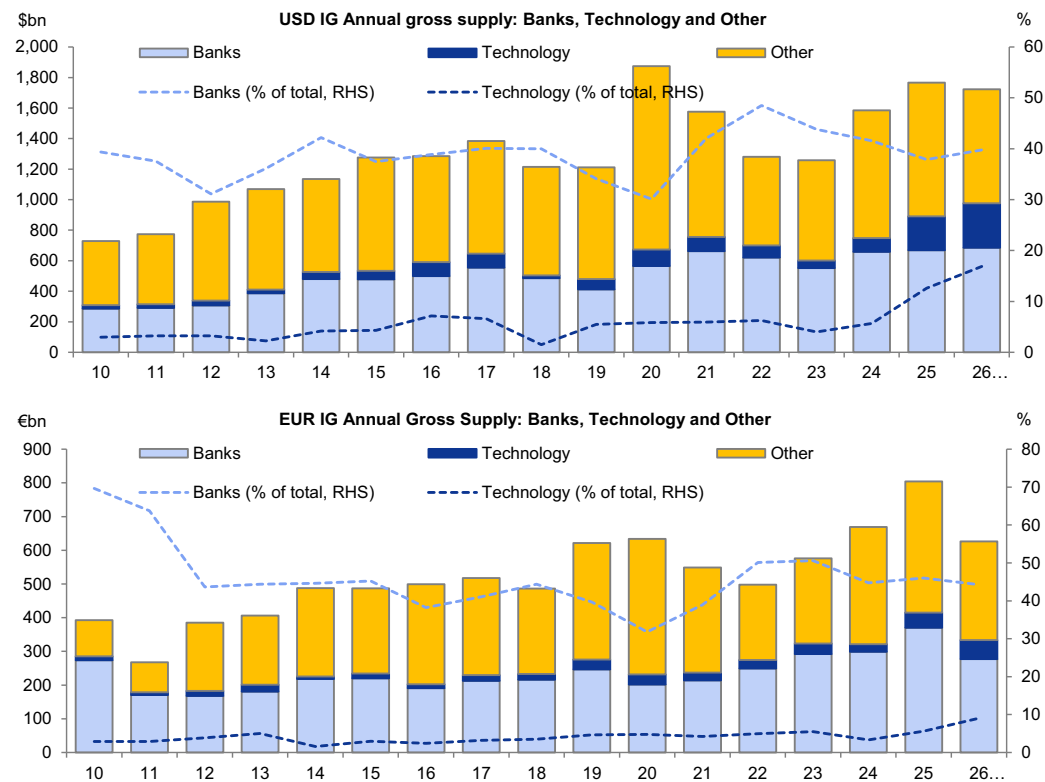
By contrast, we see little indication that banks are increasing leverage materially. Record USD IG bank supply reflects opportunistic issuance into tight spreads and, at the margin, AI-related growth in balance-sheet-intensive activities, including prime-brokerage financing of AI-related equity trading and C&I lending to companies supporting the broader AI infrastructure buildout. These activities may increase banks' use of balance sheet lending capacity through bridge facilities, underwriting commitments, trading, hedging, and lending across the AI supply chain, but we expect banks to remain selective in retaining large, long-dated AI infrastructure exposures. From a *relative* standpoint, banks' share of total USD IG supply has also been broadly stable at roughly 40% (again, Exhibit 14).

Even if direct lending increases more materially, the scope of the AI buildout will likely be too large for bank balance sheets and syndicated debt markets to fund alone. We expect private markets—including infrastructure, real estate, credit and equity—to provide an increasingly important share of long-duration financing. Large banks should nevertheless remain central to originating, underwriting, syndicating, financing and hedging the AI capex cycle, with the greatest opportunity likely accruing to global firms

with broad capital markets platforms. While recent headlines have focused some market participants on the potential pace of the AI buildout, our equity colleagues recently highlighted a growing supply-demand imbalance for AI and expect the capex cycle to remain elevated through the end of 2027.

Exhibit 14: We expect supply to continue rising in the Technology sector

Gross USD (top panel) and EUR (bottom panel) IG supply year-to-date vs. rest of year



Source: Dealogic, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

We thank Patricia Pacheco for her contribution to this report.

Disclosure Appendix

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We, Sara Grut, Amanda Lynam, CPA, Arun Manohar, Spencer Rogers, CFA, Shamshad Ali, Ben Shumway and Neth Karunamuni, hereby certify that all of the views expressed in this report accurately reflect our personal views, which have not been influenced by considerations of the firm's business or client relationships.

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